OPEN SOURCE · FOR STARTUPS

16

open-source tools, 16 jobs a startup pays for

The startup stack, if you refuse to sign a per-seat contract in year one.

Star counts checked today. No prices quoted because yours depend on seats and hosting. What each one replaces, and where it bites.

943k

GitHub stars between them

SELL AND TALK TO CUSTOMERS

Pipeline, inbox, bookings

Twenty

60k stars

replaces the job of HubSpot / Pipedrive

Chatwoot

38k stars

replaces the job of Intercom / Zendesk

Cal.com

49k stars

replaces the job of Calendly

The catch: Twenty is young and moves fast. Pin a version. Chatwoot's WhatsApp setup is the slow part.

KNOW WHAT'S HAPPENING

Analytics and feedback

PostHog

40k stars

replaces the job of Mixpanel / Amplitude

Plausible

29k stars

replaces the job of Google Analytics

Formbricks

13k stars

replaces the job of Typeform / Hotjar surveys

The catch: PostHog self-hosted wants a real server. Their cloud free tier is generous enough that most teams should just use it.

RUN THE BACK OFFICE

Paperwork and money

Documenso

15k stars

replaces the job of DocuSign

Invoice Ninja

10k stars

replaces the job of FreshBooks

listmonk

24k stars

replaces the job of Mailchimp

The catch: e-signatures in regulated industries have compliance rules. Read Documenso's page before anything legal moves.

BUILD AND AUTOMATE

The plumbing

n8n — 209k stars
replaces the job of Zapier / Make

Supabase — 114k stars
replaces the job of Firebase

NocoDB — 65k stars
replaces the job of Airtable

The catch: someone owns updates. n8n's free self-hosted tier is the best deal here; Supabase's cloud free tier is where most teams should start.

THINK AND MAKE

Docs, AI, design, bots

Outline — 41k stars
replaces the job of Notion / Confluence

Open WebUI — 157k stars
replaces the job of ChatGPT Team

Penpot — 61k stars
replaces the job of Figma

Typebot — 10k stars
replaces the job of Landbot / Tidio

The catch: Penpot is a Figma alternative for product work, not a Canva one for social posts. Different job.

WHERE OPEN SOURCE BITES

Before you pick any of these, be honest about three things

	Hosted SaaS	Self-hosted OSS
Someone else fixes it at 2am	✓	–
Per-seat bill grows with hiring	✓	–
Your data on your server	–	✓
Setup in an afternoon	✓	–
Free tier that stays free	–	✓
Vendor can change pricing on you	✓	–

Our rule: self-host the boring, stable stuff. Pay for the thing that pages you at night.

IF YOU'RE STARTING FROM ZERO

Pick one job, not sixteen

01 Write down the three tools you'd pay for first. Usually a CRM, a support inbox and automation.

02 Try the open-source one for exactly one of them. One small server is enough.

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docker compose up -d
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03 Run it alongside the paid tool for two weeks. If nobody notices, cancel. If they do, you learned what you're paying for.

04 Only then pick the next job.

Most teams that try all sixteen at once end up back on the paid stack in a month.

OUR BIAS, STATED



Open source is not free. It trades a monthly bill for a weekend and a little responsibility. For most things under 20 people, that's a good trade.

— Founder Signal

One tool, automation or honest comparison for startups, every weekday.

Repos and the star counts we checked are in the first comment. Tell us the job we missed.

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